NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.
1NT Opening: 15-17 points
2NT Opening: 20-21 points
1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit
2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.
In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.
Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥2

Board: 2
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣K

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♣J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: North
Lead: ♠K

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥Q

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ A 10 8 5
♥ K Q 7 4
♦ A Q J
♣ K J

♠ Q 6 4
♥ A 10 8 3
♦ 10 9 8 2
♣ 9 6



♠ J 3
♥ J 9 5 2
♦ K 6 5
♣ A 8 5 2

♠ K 9 7 2
♥ 6
♦ 7 4 3
♣ Q 10 7 4 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	2NT	Pass	3♣
Pass	3♥	Pass	3NT
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♥2

When you have 4 cards in both Majors you respond 2♥ to a Stayman request. Partner now bids 3NT.

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Partner denies having 4 ♥s so he must have 4 ♠s (or he would not have used Stayman). You correct the contract to4♠.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥2. West grabs the opening lead with the ♥A and plays the ♦10.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

The ♠, ♥ and ♣ losers are inevitable so you'd better not lose a ♦. Even though West has returned a ♦ it is still possible that he holds the ♦K so the finesse has a chance of working. Let's say a 50% chance. Do you take it?

No, of course not. Not when you have a play that offers almost a 100% chance. Win the ♦A, play ♠K, ♠A, then ♥ K Q, discarding dummy's 2 ♦ losers.

With one master trump still out you start on the ♣s, playing first the ♣K, then overtake the ♣J with dummy's ♣Q. The defense is welcome to take their ♣A whenever they want, and they are also welcome to their trump trick. You are so gracious because you have your ten tricks!

Half the time the ♦K will be with West, and the inferior plan of taking the finesse will work. On those Deals your superior plan shows no payoff.

But the other 50% of the time East will have the ♦K. On those Deals you get your just reward.

Board 2
East Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 9 6 4 2 ♥ K Q 10 ♦ Q 10 5 ♣ 10 6 2	
♠ 7 3 ♥ 6 5 ♦ J 2 ♣ A J 9 8 7 4 3	N W E S	♠ A K 5 ♥ A 9 8 4 ♦ A 8 6 3 ♣ Q 5
	♠ Q J 10 8 ♥ J 7 3 2 ♦ K 9 7 4 ♣ K	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♠Q

You do have 9 points, of a sort anyway. Hoping your ♣ suit will be of use, you invite with 2NT. Partner says 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by West.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♠Q, North following with the ♠2. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

No, don't hold up. At least you have ♠s stopped twice, your other suits are stopped only once.

Realizing that your only hope is for a bunch of ♣ tricks you win the ♠K and play the ♣Q. South covers with the ♣K. What do you do?

If you win with dummy's ♣A, and if the ♣s split 2-2, you can win 7 ♣ tricks and 4 other high cards. Wow!

But if it turns out that the ♣K was singleton you will win just TWO ♣ tricks because dummy has no other entries.

So if you feel like gambling, go up with the ♣A. But if you like the idea of a guaranteed contract let South hold the ♣K, and you make sure of the six other ♣s.

This Deal is not a "made up" one, it was actually played at our Monday Duplicate game in May 2012.

The play went exactly as shown above. When her LHO played the ♣K our declarer ducked in dummy and made the contract.

Board 3
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ A 10 4 3 ♥ 7 3 ♦ K Q 8 7 4 2 ♣ 7	
♠ Q ♥ Q 9 8 6 2 ♦ 9 5 ♣ K Q J 9 3	N W E S	♠ K J 9 6 ♥ J 10 5 4 ♦ 10 6 ♣ 10 8 5
	♠ 8 7 5 2 ♥ A K ♦ A J 3 ♣ A 6 4 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♣	Pass	2♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♣K

It is tempting to just bid 3NT and hope the ♦s come in. But not when you have a 4-card Major suit. Instead you bid a Stayman 2♣. Partner says 2♠;

It is tempting to just bid 3NT and hope the ♦s come in. But not when you have a 4-card Major suit. Instead you bid a Stayman 2♣. Partner says 2♠;

Well, he has 4 ♠s. That's why you used Stayman so you bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by North.

South plays 4♠. West leads the ♣K. Seeing 10 top tricks sort of makes you wish you had just bid 3NT.

Loser List: ♠ = 2/3/4 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2/3/4

Missing 5 ♠s, the most likely split is 3-2, (68% of the time). You win the ♣A and play a small ♠ toward dummy. West puts on the ♠Q which you take with dummy's ♠A, East following with the ♠6.

Do you play ♠s again? or not?

Not. With both defenders following suit, the possibility of 4 ♠ losers is gone so you can lose at most 3. But that ♠Q from West is ominous. If you play another ♠ and they do split 3-2 you will make 11 tricks, losing only 2 trumps. But if East has 3 ♠s left he will win the trick, pull all the rest of the trumps, and lead a ♣ to West.

The guaranteed way to make the contract is to play no more ♠s, but to start playing ♦ winners. The defenders can make their 3 trump tricks but you maintain control of the hand.

As you see, playing a second trump would have been disastrous.

But with a different distribution, (3-2), playing the second trump would have been great.

Considering probabilities it looks like this. If you play the second trump you will make 2 overtricks about 70% of the time, but you will go down 4 about 30% of the time.

If you stop with the ♠s and start running ♦s you will make your contract 100% of the time but will never make an overtrick.

Board 4
East Deals
Both Vul

♠ A 8 5
♥ 4
♦ J 9 7 6 4 3
♣ J 10 9

♠ K 10 6 2
♥ K Q 10 8 6 3
♦ 5
♣ 7 4



♠ Q J 3
♥ A 5
♦ A K 8 2
♣ Q 8 3 2

♠ 9 7 4
♥ J 9 7 2
♦ Q 10
♣ A K 6 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♦	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♣J

\+ ?

Yes, you have a 6-card ♥ suit. But you also have 4 ♠s, so you start with a Stayman 2♣.

Partner says 2♦;

Yes, you have a 6-card ♥ suit. But you also have 4 ♠s, so you start with a Stayman 2♣.

Partner says 2♦;

OK, no 4-4 ♠ fit. But partner has at least 2♥ so you know you have an 8-card (or better) fit there. With 10 points you have to decide whether to invite or insist, and you like the looks of this hand so you bid 4♥.

West plays 4♥. North leads the ♣J. You play low from dummy and North continues with ♣10, then ♣9 which you ruff.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = ? : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 3

You don't expect a trump loser, and obviously you cannot afford to have one.

So after ruffing the third ♣ you play ♥A, then ♥Q. Aargh! North discards a ♦ on the second trump.

South has left the ♥ J 9 while you have the ♥ Q 10 8. If only dummy had another ♥ you could finesse South's ♥J, but, alas, dummy has none. Can you see another way to accomplish the finesse?

If you could manage to be in dummy after trick 11, and have nothing in your hand but the ♥ Q 10, while South had nothing in his hand but the ♥ J 9 you would have him. But to accomplish this you must use up your ♥8 beforehand.

You enter dummy with a ♦, then play a small ♦ and ruff with your ♥8. Then play your ♠K. North wins this and assume he plays another ♠.

Win the ♠ in dummy, then play ♦K, and the other ♠ winner. If South has to follow to all these then you will have accomplished your objective; South will be down to ♥ J 9 and will have to ruff trick 12 with one of them - which you will over-ruff.

One possibility was not mentioned earlier.

When you played a third ♦ to ruff with your ♥8, South **COULD** have ruffed this. If he had, it would have handed you your contract since you could over-ruff and take care of your trump problem immediately.

By the way, ruffing a card to purposely shorten your trump holding is called a Trump Coup.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A 7 2 ♥ K 5 ♦ K J 6 3 ♣ A Q 7 2	
♠ 8 4 ♥ 9 8 7 4 2 ♦ A 7 ♣ 10 6 5 3	N W E S	♠ K Q J 9 6 3 ♥ J 10 ♦ Q 10 9 ♣ 9 4
	♠ 10 5 ♥ A Q 6 3 ♦ 8 5 4 2 ♣ K J 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1NT	2♠	3♠
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠K

Partner's cue-bid is the lebensohl version of Stayman, in this case promising 4 ♥s. Since it is an immediate cue-bid it denies a ♠ stopper.

You are forced to bid and you don't have 4 ♥s.

But you **DO** have a ♠ stopper so you decide bid 3NT.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♠K.

You hold up your ♠A until the third round; East started with 6 ♠s.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

You need just one more winner. It cannot come from either ♣s or ♠s. Unless a defender foolishly discards a ♥ it can't come from that suit. Which means you have to win a ♦ trick.

So after winning the ♠A, you play a ♣ to dummy's ♣K, then lead a small ♦ toward your hand and play . . . what?

At first this looks like the classic King / Jack guess situation where you try to figure out if East is more likely to have the Ace or the Queen.

But it isn't like that at all. If East has the ♦A then he will take it no matter which ♦ you play, and will defeat you with 1 ♦ and 5 ♠ tricks. Your **ONLY** chance to make this contract is for West to hold the ♦A. So you play the ♦K, then you . . .

. . .

Lucky you, West did have the ♦A.

Smart you, if you had played the ♦J you'd be down 2.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ Q 10 4 ♥ K 10 5 2 ♦ A J 7 3 ♣ J 5	
♠ A 8 7 6 3 2 ♥ 8 ♦ K 10 5 ♣ 9 8 2		♠ K 5 ♥ A 6 4 ♦ 9 6 2 ♣ A K Q 6 3
	♠ J 9 ♥ Q J 9 7 3 ♦ Q 8 4 ♣ 10 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1NT	Pass
2♥	Pass	2♠	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥Q

You have an invitational strength hand with a 6-card Major suit. It's a no-brainer; you transfer with a 2♥ bid. Partner says 2♠;

You have an invitational strength hand with a 6-card Major suit. It's a no-brainer; you transfer with a 2♥ bid. Partner says 2♠;

Repeat: You have an **invitational** strength hand with a **6-card** Major suit. So you invite with 3♠s. Partner accepts with 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by West.

East plays 4♠. South leads the ♥Q. Of course you take the ♥A.

Loser List: ♠ = 1/2/3 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 4/5/6

Missing 5 ♠s, the most likely split is 3-2, (68% of the time). You win the ♥A then play ♠K and ♠A, both defenders following to both leads but the ♠Q is still out there.

Do you play ♠s again or not?

Usually it is a good idea to leave a master trump un-pulled and go about your business winning tricks in other suits. The idea is to force them to ruff without using any more of your trumps. But that is only "usually". Here your big source of winners is going to be the ♣ suit - and there are zero outside entries to it. Suppose you do not force out the ♠Q, but start playing ♣ winners. A defender might ruff the third ♣ and you would be doomed.

So play one more ♠ and they are doomed.

Master trump outstanding: To pull or not to pull, that is the question.

Almost always the answer is "not to pull".

The big exception is when you have a running suit in one hand but with no outside entries to it. A hand exactly like this one.